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Sarbananda Sonowal
Minister of Ports, Shipping & Waterways

A LONG HAUL

The numbers look promising, but the task to take India into the big league in global shipping remains

By Kaushik Deka

BOLD & BRAVE

SAGARMALA PORT-LED PROSPERITY

₹1.12 LAKH CRORE

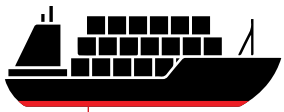
Worth of 221 SagarMala projects completed to strengthen port infra and trade efficiency

Indian Vessels Act, 2021, passed to promote transportation and trade via inland waterways

BUT...

95%

Overseas trade by volume via India's ports. Yet...



10 PER CENT

India's share in global dead-weight tonnage

INDIA'S MAJOR PORTS HANDLED a record 795 million tonnes of cargo in FY23, registering a 10 per cent year-on-year growth. The Union government's flagship SagarMala programme has played a key role in strengthening the port infrastructure and trade efficiency, harnessing India's 7,500 km coastline, 14,500 km potentially navigable waterways and strategic location on key international maritime trade routes.

Under the programme, 802 projects worth Rs 5.4 lakh crore are to be completed by 2035. Of these, 221 projects worth Rs 1.12 lakh crore have been completed while the remaining 581 are under various stages of implementation. But Sarbananda Sonowal, who is at the helm of the ministry since July 2021, still faces the challenge to take India to the big league in global shipping.

Nearly 95 per cent of India's overseas trade by volume is carried out via its ports. Yet, India accounts for just over 10 per cent of the global deadweight tonnage. The reasons are aplenty: the lack of a robust local shipbuilding ecosystem, non-availability of new technology alternatives or retrofitting options, and the age profile of the merchant shipping fleet (most vessels are around 20 years vintage). To make amends, the government has approved a scheme under Aatmanirbhar Bharat to provide Rs 1,624 crore over a period of five years to make Indian shipping companies globally competitive.

By 2030, the government also envisions a three-fold increase in inland waterway transport—an eco-friendly and cheaper option to supplement the overburdened railways and congested roads. To facilitate the ease of doing business, the Inland Vessels Act, 2021, has been passed, replacing an over 100-year-old law. Inland waterways also handled 126 million tonnes of cargo in 2022-23, a 16 per cent jump from last fiscal.

The next focus is on green shipping. To meet the zero carbon emission goal, the ministry has launched 'Harit Sagar', the Green Port Guidelines, in May 2023. The ministry is also working on a Rs 5,000 crore package to facilitate the construction of vessels for inland waterways under the Make in India initiative. It will help decarbonise the sector by introducing alternative fuel technologies for vessels. ■